

What Is Machine Learning?

Machine learning (ML) is defined as a discipline of artificial intelligence (AI) that provides machines the ability to automatically learn from data and past experiences to identify patterns and make predictions with minimal human intervention.

The term machine learning was first introduced by **Arthur Samuel** in **1959**.

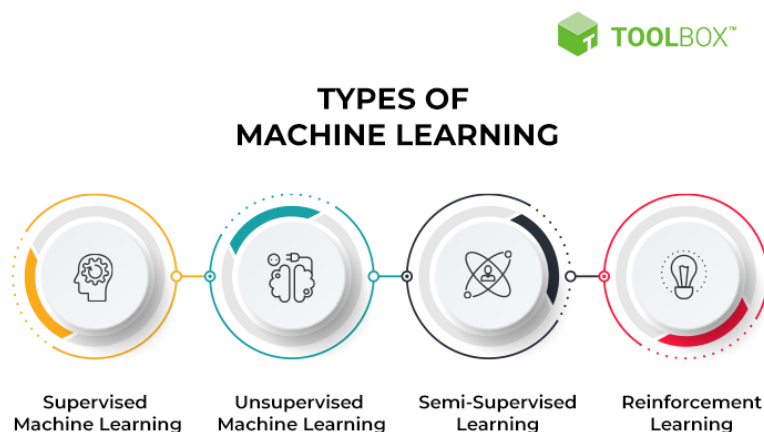
Machine learning enables a machine to automatically learn from data, improve performance from experiences, and predict things without being explicitly programmed.

With the help of sample historical data, which is known as training data, machine learning algorithms build a mathematical model that helps in making predictions or decisions without being explicitly programmed.

Machine learning brings computer science and statistics together for creating predictive models.

Types of Machine Learning

Machine learning algorithms can be trained in many ways, with each method having its pros and cons. Based on these methods and ways of learning, machine learning is broadly categorized into four main types:



1. Supervised machine learning

This type of ML involves supervision, where machines are trained on labeled datasets and enabled to predict outputs based on the provided training. The labeled dataset specifies that some input and output parameters are already mapped. Hence, the machine is trained with the input and corresponding output. A device is made to predict the outcome using the test dataset in subsequent phases.

For example, consider an input dataset of parrot and crow images. Initially, the machine is trained to understand the pictures, including the parrot and crow's color, eyes, shape, and size. Post-training, an input picture of a parrot is provided, and the machine is expected to identify the object and predict the output. The trained machine checks for the various features of the object, such as color, eyes, shape, etc., in the input picture, to make a final prediction. This is the process of object identification in supervised machine learning.

The primary objective of the supervised learning technique is to map the input variable (a) with the output variable (b). Supervised machine learning is further classified into two broad categories:

- **Classification:** These refer to algorithms that address classification problems where the output variable is categorical; for example, yes or no, true or false, male or female, etc. Real-world applications of this category are evident in spam detection and email filtering.
- **Regression:** Regression algorithms handle regression problems where input and output variables have a linear relationship. These are known to predict continuous output variables. Examples include weather prediction, market trend analysis, etc.

2. Unsupervised machine learning

Unsupervised learning refers to a learning technique that's devoid of supervision. Here, the machine is trained using an unlabeled dataset and is enabled to predict the output without any supervision.

An unsupervised learning algorithm aims to group the unsorted dataset based on the input's similarities, differences, and patterns.

For example, consider an input dataset of images of a fruit-filled container. Here, the images are not known to the machine learning model.

When we input the dataset into the ML model, the task of the model is to identify the pattern of objects, such as color, shape, or differences seen in the input images and categorize them. Upon categorization, the machine then predicts the output as it gets tested with a test dataset.

Unsupervised machine learning is further classified into two types:

- **Clustering:** The clustering technique refers to grouping objects into clusters based on parameters such as similarities or differences between objects. For example, grouping customers by the products they purchase.
- **Association:** Association learning refers to identifying typical relations between the variables of a large dataset. It determines the dependency of various data items and maps associated variables. Typical applications include web usage mining and market data analysis.

3. Semi-supervised learning

Semi-supervised learning comprises characteristics of both supervised and unsupervised machine learning. It uses the combination of labeled and unlabeled datasets to train its algorithms. Using both types of datasets, semi-supervised learning overcomes the drawbacks of the options mentioned above.

Consider an example of a college student. A student learning a concept under a teacher's supervision in college is termed supervised learning. In unsupervised learning, a student self-learns the same concept at home without a teacher's guidance. Meanwhile, a student revising the concept after learning under the direction of a teacher in college is a semi-supervised form of learning.

4. Reinforcement learning

Reinforcement learning is a feedback-based process. Here, the AI component automatically takes stock of its surroundings by the hit & trial method, takes action, learns from experiences, and improves performance.

The component is rewarded for each good action and penalized for every wrong move. Thus, the reinforcement learning component aims to maximize the rewards by performing good actions.

Unlike supervised learning, reinforcement learning lacks labeled data, and the agents learn via experiences only.

Consider video games. Here, the game specifies the environment, and each move of the reinforcement agent defines its state. The agent is entitled to receive feedback via punishment and rewards, thereby affecting the overall game score. The ultimate goal of the agent is to achieve a high score.